the telegram. On the doctor's advice, they had brought him home. Father died on the third day.

It was only now that I realised I hailed from a financially mediocre family, and its prime breadwinner was no more. By providing us everything we needed, father had shielded us from the financial constraints of bringing up five children with his sole income. Now, that shield was gone.

Two of my elder sisters were married, and there were two more to be taken care of. Mother looked up to me, and I looked inward. There was a discussion whether I should continue my studies or take over father's business. My two brothers-in-law, who were prospective successors to father's business, backed out.

Suddenly, I was a responsible person. And that can be tough at the age of nineteen, when you dream of getting an engineering degree and probably going abroad for higher studies. Fortunately for me, two of my sisters put their foot down: 'Nambi will continue to study.'

Another blessing—and a big one at that—was the merit-cum-means national scholarship my academic record had ensured. The money—Rs 1,400 a year—was enough to meet my study-related expenses. As for my occasional visit from the campus in Madurai to the family in Nagercoil, the sisters chipped in. I was back in college. While I mingled with a large number of students who had come to the campus from far and wide, three of us from Nagercoil—A Chandran, Lawrence and I—remained as 'the gang'. We would go to our native place together during holidays, and were like an extended family. Lawrence's father, a retired army man, was entangled in a false case and the burden of running the family fell on his mother. She did this gracefully, and the pleasant woman remained a source of motherly love for all of us.

Chandran's father Mr N A Appan was a jovial man. Having retired as a labour commissioner in Singapore and returned to Nagercoil, he welcomed, mockingly, the devaluation of the Indian rupee at that time. He would joke that now his pension, when converted to Indian currency, was more than his salary. Lawrence later became a Colonel in the Indian Army; Chandran